

How to Successfully Evaluate Your Players



Balanced Teams is one of the six AYSO philosophies and a hallmark of the organization. For 8U and above, player ratings provide important information for forming balanced teams.

PLAYER EVALUATION AND RATING

Towards the end of the fall season, each coach in 8U and above rates all of their players and submits those ratings to the respective Division Director. All player ratings remain confidential among the Division Director and coaches.

The resulting ratings are used to balance teams for the following fall season and for the spring season if there is a competitive spring program.

Player ratings use a scale of 1 through 5, with 0.5 increments permitted for rating differentiation. Players should be compared to **ALL** players in the division, not just against the players on your team. Think of several game situations this season and determine which number below best describes the player as they compare to all players on the field:

- **5 - High impact player:** Can carry a team; excellent individual and team skills; leader.
- **4 - Strong player:** Good individual and team skills; very good at multiple positions or excellent at one position (e.g. goalkeeper); would make any team better.
- **3 - Average player:** Has basic skills and understanding of the game; generally does not impact the game positively or negatively.
- **2 - Below average player:** Does not have basic skills or game sense; emerging skills.
- **1 - Beginning or disruptive player:** Has never played before; has little skill or understanding of the game; or is disruptive to a team.

Players rated 4 and above are positive game changers. Players rated below 3 are neutral game changers who may have periods of positive impact and periods of negative impact depending on the skill category. Players rated in the 1's and 2's may negatively impact the game or hinder the team's progress either defensively or offensively.

RATING GUIDELINES				
5	4	3	2	1
High impact can carry a team; excellent individual and team skills; leader.	Strong good individual and team skills; very good at multiple positions or excellent at one position (e.g. goalkeeper); would make any team better.	Average has basic skills and understanding of the game; generally does not impact the game (positively or negatively).	Below Average does not have basic skills or game sense.	Player who has never played before; has little skill or understanding of the game; or player that is disruptive to a team.

EVALUATION CATEGORIES AND RATING

Speed & Endurance

Speed

The player's pure running velocity with and without the ball.

- **5:** Explodes past defenders; routinely wins long footraces to loose balls; maintains top speed while dribbling.
- **4:** Fast; consistently beats average players to the ball; can track down attackers or break away on a sprint.
- **3:** Average pace; keeps up with the flow of the game; neither outruns nor gets easily left behind by the pack.
- **2:** Visibly slow; struggles to catch up to plays; frequently gets beaten to loose balls.
- **1:** Lacks running mechanics; walks or jogs during active transitions; severely limited pace.

Endurance

The player's stamina and energy levels across an entire half or match.

- **5:** Never seems to tire; sprints just as hard in the final minutes as the first; does not request substitutions.
 - **4:** Highly conditioned; maintains high energy for most of the game; only shows minor fatigue late in the half.
 - **3:** Average stamina; plays hard but needs normal rest/substitutions; paces themselves to last the game.
 - **2:** Tires quickly; stops running or switches to a walk after a few long sprints; visibly winded early on.
 - **1:** Minimal stamina; lacks the physical conditioning to run for more than a couple minutes; requires immediate and frequent breaks or subbing.
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Technical Skills

Ball Handling

Dribbling, close control, first touch, and ability to keep the ball under pressure.

- **5:** Glues the ball to their feet; uses both feet smoothly; executes moves/turns to beat defenders in tight spaces.
- **4:** Clean first touch; comfortably dribbles open space; keeps composure and control when approached by a defender; maintains possession most of the time.
- **3:** Can dribble straight lines under low pressure; first touch sometimes bounces away but they recover it; loses possession half of the time.
- **2:** Struggles to control the ball; dribbles with heavy touches that run out of bounds or straight into defenders; frequently loses possession.
- **1:** Trips over the ball; cannot trap or control a pass; accidentally kicks the ball away when trying to dribble; cannot maintain possession.

Kicking

Passing accuracy, shooting power, clearing distance, and proper technique.

- **5:** Strikes cleanly with power and accuracy using both feet; drives long passes; shoots intentionally into corners; always uses the correct technique.
 - **4:** Consistent technique with dominant foot; lifts the ball intentionally; makes accurate pass selections to teammates; does not use their toe to kick with power.
 - **3:** Can pass accurately to a nearby teammate under low pressure; can clear the ball, but direction and distance vary; may use good technique occasionally.
 - **2:** Uses toe-kicks exclusively ("toe-punts"); passes have no weight or accuracy; cannot clear the ball out of danger.
 - **1:** Misses the ball entirely (whiffs); passes go straight to opponents; lacks the strength to move the ball more than a few yards; poor technique.
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Game Sense & Attitude

Awareness

Understanding of positions, spacing, tactical decision-making, and "soccer IQ."

- **5:** Mentally ahead of the play; constantly directs teammates; moves into open space *before* the ball arrives; holds their position perfectly; extremely coachable.
- **4:** Understands their position and role; looks up before passing and scans the field for opportunities; tracks back defensively without being told; very coachable.
- **3:** Understands basic rules and positions, but sometimes "magnetizes" to the ball or forgets where they should be standing; may take a few times to adapt to coach instruction.
- **2:** Frequently out of position; chases the ball aimlessly (bunching); doesn't know which direction their team is attacking; takes many times to understand coach instructions.
- **1:** Completely lost on the field; stands still during active plays; turns away from the ball or ignores the game entirely.

Aggressive (Competitive Drive / Engagement)

Physicality, hunger for the ball, and willingness to contest challenges.

- **5:** Fearless; actively hunts the ball; steps firmly into tackles; wins 50/50 challenges without hesitation; uses body effectively without causing fouls.
- **4:** Confident and competitive; attacks the ball rather than waiting for it; uses their body legally to shield or win possession often.
- **3:** Competes when the ball is nearby; will defend or challenge but handles heavy contact cautiously.
- **2:** Timid; hesitates or backs away from incoming balls and opposing players; avoids physical contact.
- **1:** Afraid of the ball; actively runs away from contact or incoming kicks; hides behind other players or avoids contact.

Attendance

Reliability and commitment to practices and matches.

- **5:** Perfect or near-perfect attendance; arrives early or on time; always communicates absences well in advance.
- **4:** Highly reliable; rarely misses a practice or game; always arrives ready to play.
- **3:** Average attendance; misses an occasional practice due to conflicts but makes almost all games.
- **2:** Spotty attendance; frequently misses weekday practices; occasionally misses games without advanced warning.
- **1:** Rarely attends; misses most practices and multiple games; unreliable schedule disrupts team planning.

Goalkeeping

Shot-stopping, handling, positioning, distribution, and understanding of goalkeeping concepts and tactical decision-making in the box.

- **Yes - Advanced:** Outstanding shot-stopper; commands the penalty box; cleanly catches hard shots rather than giving up rebounds; distributes accurately by hand or foot to launch counter-attacks; completely fearless when coming off their line to challenge a breakaway.
- **Yes - Average:** Competent but basic keeper; can stop shots kicked directly at them; handles easy bounces safely; uses hands properly instead of field feet, but struggles with high balls or shots aimed into the corners; does not consistently dive for the ball.
- **Yes - Beginner:** Uncomfortable in goal; stands flat-footed on the goal line; slaps or bobbles easy balls; hesitant to use their hands or dive; dives *after* the ball has already passed them.
- **No:** Refuses or is highly reluctant to play keeper; No interest in this position.

Essential Team Roles

Parent/Guardian Volunteer

As AYSO is an all-volunteer organization, parent/guardian involvement is a key factor to balancing teams and effective team formation.

- **Head Coach**
- **Assistant Coach**
- **Team Manager**
- **Referee**
- **Other Volunteer** (such as Field Marshal, Field Set Up, Picture Day, etc.)
- **Did not Volunteer** (parent/guardian did not volunteer for anything this season)